

Berkeley: *Third Dialogue*

January 22nd, 2004

Common Sense

- Berkeley claims that his philosophy is a vindication of common sense (I26): he thinks ordinary people's beliefs are consistent with his metaphysical views.
- So ordinary people are right when they say that there are stars, trees, houses, cherries, oars...
 - How can these claims be reconciled with the claim that there are no material objects?

- Berkeley's view: cherries, etc., exist, but they are not material objects. What are they then?

Since it is not a being distinct from sensations; a *cherry*, I say, is nothing but a congeries [i.e. collection or bundle] of sensible impressions, or ideas perceived by various senses: which ideas are united into one thing (or have one name given them) by the mind; because they are observed to attend each other. (130).

- What does Berkeley mean by saying that the ideas are united into one thing 'by the mind'? Surely he doesn't think that people *make* cherries?
 - He's got to mean that our observations give us *reason* to think that our sensations are constituents of a cherry.

- Another key passage:

Strictly speaking, Hylas, we do not see the same object that we feel; neither is the same object perceived by the microscope, which was by the naked eye. But in case every variation was thought sufficient to constitute a new kind or individual, the endless number or confusion of names would render language impracticable.

Therefore to avoid this as well as other inconveniences which are obvious upon a little thought, men combine together several ideas, apprehended by divers senses, or by the same sense at different times, or in different circumstances, but observed however to have some connexion in Nature...; all of which they refer to one name, and consider as one thing. (I27)

- Presumably a cherry (or whatever) will typically contain the ideas of many different perceivers.
 - Including God!
 - These ideas will be quite dissimilar to one another if the perceivers see the cherry from different angles, using different senses, with different sorts of apparatus (e.g. microscopes, yellow lenses), at different times...
 - Which of God's many ideas is included in a given cherry?
 - If in fact no-one ever looks at the cherry through yellow lenses, will the cherry still include yellowish ideas of God's?

Attributing properties to 'common objects'

- What do we mean when we say that a certain cherry is red, or that a certain oar is crooked? Surely it can't be the exact same thing that we mean when we say that a single idea perceived by just one person is red or crooked!

Hylas: Since, according to you, men judge of the reality of things by their senses, how can a man be mistaken in thinking the moon a plain lucid surface, about a foot in diameter; or a square tower, seen at a distance, round; or an oar, with one end in the water, crooked?

Philonous: He is not mistaken with regard to the ideas he actually perceives; but in the inferences he makes from his present perceptions. Thus in the case of the oar, what he immediately perceives by sight is certainly crooked; and so far he is in the right. But if he thence conclude, that upon taking the oar out of the water he shall perceive the same crookedness, or that it would affect his touch, as crooked things are wont to do: in that he is mistaken.

- This suggests a recipe for ‘paraphrasing’ claims about common objects using counterfactuals about one’s own experience.
- ‘I am looking at a crooked oar’ becomes ‘if I were to take the oar out of the water, I would have crooked sensations’.
 - Or better: ‘if I were to have a succession of sensations as of reaching out for the oar, seeing my arms approaching it, feeling my hands going into the water, feeling the hardness of the oar, and feeling my hands pulling something out of the water, I would have crooked sensations.’
 - The paraphrases are going to have to be very complicated!

- But how is this to be understood in terms of the ‘congeries of ideas’ picture? If an oar is a congeries of ideas, what is it for such a thing to be straight or bent?
 - Suggestion: the congeries is bent if the ‘best’ members of it are bent.
 - ‘Best’ in what sense? The ones God would show to someone who was in ideal conditions.
 - How is ‘ideal conditions’ to be cashed out?

- Q: Is it inconsistent of Berkeley to insist on the univocality of words like 'red' and 'crooked' when he's arguing against the existence of matter, and then to claim that these words are ambiguous in the way I just described?